

The Extra-Click Advantage

A Pre-Production A/B/C Experiment — Mobile Day-One Onboarding

A design that required one extra click cut onboarding time by more than half, overturning the team's own hypothesis, and surfacing a deeper risk in the app's information architecture before it rolled out to every HCM customer.

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Problem

Workday's mobile onboarding experience is being redesigned to let frontline and deskless workers complete Day One setup entirely within the app. The strategic goal for this initiative is to lift mobile adoption and eventually replace the legacy Onboarding Dashboard for every HCM customer. The team was adding a new, manager-personalized message into an already dense information architecture, and needed to know where it could live without adding to the cognitive load of a new hire's first day: folded into the main landing page for immediate visibility, or tucked into a dedicated personalized tab that costs an extra click.

Role & Context

I led study design, prototype testing, data analysis, and reporting for this experiment.

This study was run by a cross-functional Onboarding team: a PM, researcher/designer, and design technologists. The team had already gathered employee-attitude research showing that manager-authored content matters especially to frontline workers, and came into the study needing evidence for exactly where that content should go.

Hypothesis & Design

Initial hypothesis: The team expected the opposite of what we ultimately recommended: that placing the message on the first tab, under Announcements (Variant B), would produce the highest success, efficiency, and perceived findability, since it kept the message on the main landing page users saw first.

Method: 306 frontline workers, randomized into three groups of roughly 100, each shown one of three placements for an identical welcome message.

- **Variant A - Highlights:** message shown in a highlight reel at the top of the landing ("Plan") page.
- **Variant B - Announcements:** message shown as the first card in an "Announcements" section on the Plan page.
- **Variant C - For You:** message shown as the first card inside a separate "For You" navigation tab.

Task: After a warm-up task (finding a culture-training card, used only to gauge each participant's baseline exploration behavior), participants were asked to find their manager's welcome message. Success was a direct click on the message.

Process & Decisions

- **Success is measured by outcome, not path:** the team decided upfront that success would count the moment a user tapped the correct element, regardless of how many clicks it took to get there, which is what made it possible to notice that Variant C won even with an extra required tap.
- **The warm-up task was deliberately “throwaway,” until it wasn’t:** task 1 (finding a culture card) was included purely to get users exploring the app and control for individual differences in exploration behavior; the team wasn’t initially interested in its data on its own.
- **Distractor content was added intentionally:** generic content (a team welcome card, other people, other managers) was included to mimic what a real customer app would look like, rather than testing a stripped-down prototype.
- **Statistical adjustment for exploration:** because participants naturally explored the app at different rates, we adjusted for each person’s warm-up task behavior (i.e., clicks and tabs visited) so that differences between variants reflected the design itself, not individual curiosity.

Results

The assumption that didn’t hold

The team’s working assumption — that keeping the message on the landing page under Announcements would win — turned out to be wrong. Variant B did outperform Variant A, but Variant C, the one place nobody expected users to accept an extra click for, won outright on every metric that mattered. The result wasn’t just a design decision; it was a correction to the team’s own mental model of how frontline workers navigate the app.

The extra-click paradox

Variant C required one more click to even enter the tab, yet it won on every measure that mattered: fastest median time on task (24 sec vs. 33 sec for B and 52 sec for A), fewest total clicks to complete (3 vs. 7 vs. 12), and the highest findability (80%), usability (93/100), and confidence (91%) scores. Success rate was tied with Variant B at 96%, both far ahead of Variant A’s 81%.

Cumulative-completion data sharpened the picture further: 77% of Variant C users reached the message in exactly 2 clicks once inside the tab, the theoretical minimum, and 90% finished within 4 clicks. Variant A users, by contrast, needed as many as 12 clicks to reach that same level of certainty.

Metric	A — Highlights	B — Announcements	C — For You
Success rate	81%	96%	96%
Median time on task	52 sec	33 sec	24 sec
Clicks to complete	12	7	3
Findability (% high)	37%	60%	80%
Usability score (/100)	70	85	93
Confidence (% high)	50%	80%	91%

Core metrics by variant (A: n=104, B: n=101, C: n=101).

Root cause: mental-model gravity

Behavioral data explains why the extra click didn't cost Variant C anything: users already expected personalized content to live in the "For You" tab, regardless of where the message actually was. In Variant A, 76% of users clicked into that tab anyway, and it was literally their first action 72% of the time; in Variant B, 47% of users did the same, first for 42% of them. Once inside, they kept searching into "People to Meet" and "Helpful Contacts" areas, still looking for their manager's message.

The takeaway: click count is a weaker predictor of effort than whether a design matches the mental model users already bring with them. Variant C won not by minimizing steps, but by putting the message exactly where users were already going to look.

An IA Risk Ahead of a Full Rollout

Task 1 was designed as a disposable warm-up — just a way to get participants moving through the app before the real test began. It ended up surfacing a more consequential problem than the placement question itself. Across all three variants, success on that unrelated task stalled at roughly 60%, only 30% of users found the right card on their first click, and 61% of users clicked into the "For You" tab even though it had nothing to do with the task — nearly matching the 59% who found the correct card on the Plan page. Over half of participants also clicked on non-interactive elements, a common signal of confusion-driven exploration.

Metric	Task 1 — Baseline IA (all 306 users)	Task 2 — Variant C (winner)
Success rate	~60% (notably low)	96%
Median time on task	62–89 sec	24 sec
Avg. clicks to complete	10–16 clicks	3 clicks
Findability (% high)	39%–48%	80%
Confidence (% high)	60%–68%	91%

Baseline Task 1 performance (all variants, n=306) vs. Task 2's Variant C win.

This matters beyond this one experiment. The product's stated goal is to replace the legacy Onboarding Dashboard for every HCM customer, which means this IA, overloaded or not, is on a path to much broader exposure. The "For You" tab's gravity wasn't specific to the manager-message task; it showed up even when users were looking for something else entirely. That reframes it from a placement insight into an architecture signal: before scaling this experience to all customers, the underlying navigation model - not just where any one piece of content sits within it - needs to be addressed.

Recommendations

- **Adopt Variant C** (the "For You" tab) as the placement for manager welcome messages in the Day One experience.
- **Treat the Task 1 finding as a rollout risk, not a footnote:** validate and address the broader IA-overload problem before this experience replaces the legacy dashboard for all HCM customers.
- **Reduce reliance on Plan-page "shortcuts"** such as highlight reels and announcement cards for time-sensitive personal content, since users routinely bypass them.

- **Extend the “meet users where they already look” principle** to other Day-One content such as tasks, contacts, required learning, which currently compete for space on the landing page.

Impact

The recommended design, Variant C - the “For You” tab placement, was pushed to production. The Task 1 findings also had a direct effect beyond this one placement decision: they kicked off additional work on the app’s learning content, targeting the IA-overload and horizontal-swipe friction that the baseline task exposed.

Learnings

Minimizing clicks is a common design heuristic, but this study shows it can be the wrong optimization target: the design with the most steps won because it matched user intuition. The misclick and “gravity” analysis that tracked where users went even when they were wrong was what surfaced that mental model; success-rate and survey data alone would have shown Variant C winning without ever explaining why.

It’s also worth noting the study almost discarded its most important finding. Task 1 was built to be throwaway data, useful only for statistical adjustment, but it’s what revealed that the IA problem was bigger than any single placement decision. It is worth keeping an eye on “warm-up” or control data in future studies rather than treating it as pure overhead.